



players — Nijat Abasov and Firouzja — to snatch victories and move half a point ahead of the field. Similarly, top seed Caruana got his campaign back on track by beating Vidit and Praggnanandhaa to go into the final round with hope. Nakamura, too, came into the title hunt with a hat-trick of victories and a draw with Nepomniachtchi. With the final-round pairings clubbing four contenders over two boards, Gukesh needed a draw against Nakamura to at least book his spot in the tie-break games, if needed. Nakamura too faced a must-win situation, much like Caruana and Nepomniachtchi did in their encounter.

As it turned out, Gukesh offered nothing to Nakamura from the white side and cruised to an easy draw. This result took Nakamura out of the equation. The focus was firmly on the nervy battle, where Caruana looked like he was closing in on an important victory over Nepomniachtchi. A decisive result on this board would have led to tie-break games involving Gukesh. Caruana, looking good enough to win on many occasions, eventually cracked and misplayed the position. Nepomniachtchi, on his part, came up with a timely sacrifice of his rook for a bishop and pawn and hung on. Caruana once again overlooked the precise continuation and, later, offered a draw to Nepomniachtchi. An equally exasperated

Nepomniachtchi, who also needed a win to challenge Gukesh, took a few moments to consider the draw offer. He eventually extended his hand and accepted Caruana's offer by saying, "I am sorry." Before leaving the table, Nepomniachtchi once again apologised to Caruana for offering such a stubborn defence and spoiling his rival's chances of forcing tie-break games with Gukesh. Caruana quietly responded, "My fault."

In the meantime, Gukesh, who had seen Caruana inching closer to a win, left the venue for his hotel room. "I wanted to prepare for the tie-break games (against Caruana, scheduled on the following day), but I could not bear to watch the game between Caruana and Nepomniachtchi. It was a roller-coaster game. I was as tense as the players. So, Gajewski and I decided to go for a walk," he said. "We were out for a walk when my dad walked up and told us it was all over and I was the champion. I was so relieved. Now, I'm very happy to win this event and be the Candidate."

## D. Gukesh

Rank

**1st**

Seeding

**6**

Rating

**2743**

Performance Rating

**2847**

Rating points gained

**20.4**

### Points scored – 9/14

| Rd | Seed | Opponent           | Country    | Rating | Colour | Result     | Rank     |
|----|------|--------------------|------------|--------|--------|------------|----------|
| 1  | 7    | Vidit Gujrathi     | India      | 2727   | White  | Draw       | 6th      |
| 2  | 5    | R. Praggnanandhaa  | India      | 2747   | Black  | <b>Won</b> | 5th      |
| 3  | 4    | Ian Nepomniachtchi | FIDE       | 2758   | White  | Draw       | Tied 2nd |
| 4  | 1    | Fabiano Caruana    | USA        | 2803   | Black  | Draw       | Tied 2nd |
| 5  | 8    | Nijat Abasov       | Azerbaijan | 2632   | White  | <b>Won</b> | 8th      |
| 6  | 2    | Hikaru Nakamura    | USA        | 2789   | White  | Draw       | Tied 2nd |
| 7  | 3    | Alireza Firouzja   | France     | 2760   | Black  | Lost       | 7th      |
| 8  | 7    | Vidit Gujrathi     | India      | 2727   | Black  | <b>Won</b> | 6th      |
| 9  | 6    | R. Praggnanandhaa  | India      | 2747   | White  | Draw       | 5th      |
| 10 | 3    | Ian Nepomniachtchi | FIDE       | 2758   | Black  | Draw       | Tied 2nd |
| 11 | 1    | Fabiano Caruana    | USA        | 2803   | White  | Draw       | Tied 2nd |
| 12 | 8    | Nijat Abasov       | Azerbaijan | 2632   | Black  | <b>Won</b> | 8th      |
| 13 | 3    | Alireza Firouzja   | France     | 2760   | White  | <b>Won</b> | 7th      |
| 14 | 2    | Hikaru Nakamura    | USA        | 2789   | Black  | Draw       | Tied 2nd |